

Sentinels of the Dawn

Newsletter of the Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Monastere de Notre Dame des Anges Troyes France

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New Beginnings

"This is what I am looking for! This is what I desire to do with all my heart!" Such was the response of Our Holy Father Francis after hearing the Gospel passage of Our Lord sending forth His disciples to preach. When he learned that they were to have no money or sack or provisions of food, nor a staff or sandals, but only a spare tunic, he was filled with joy. He hastened to carry out what he had heard.

This turning point in the life of Our Holy Father Francis occurred at the Portiuncula—a small chapel, dedicated to Our Lady of the Angels, which he repaired stone by stone and whose name means «little portion». He very much treasured this little chapel for it was here that he and his followers first worked, prayed, and grew in number. "See to it that you never abandon this place," he said to his brothers. "Should you be driven out one way, come back another way. For this place is truly holy and God's abode. Here He enlightened the hearts of His poor with the light of wisdom, and here He inflamed our wills with the fire of His love...» (Thomas Celano, *First Life; XII,106)*

Years later, a new branch of life appeared on the Franciscan family tree. The first humble beginnings of our Order of Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration were consecrated to the powerful intercession of the Immaculata by Mother Marie de Sainte Claire and her first followers on the 8th of December 1854 in Paris. Less than two years later, they planted their roots in Troyes, France and dedicated the first monastery, the Portiuncula of our Order, to Our Lady of the Angels. It was in this place that our Foundress, Mother Marie de Sainte Claire and her Sisters lived, prayed, worked and grew in number. From here the Order spread to Poland, Austria, the United States, Germany, and even as far away as Bangladesh and India over the next century and a half. Unfortunately, religious vocations dwindled in France as in many Western countries, and the few elderly Sisters who remained in our beloved cradle monastery were unable to continue. So on July 16, 1997 four of the oldest Sisters went to our monastery in Castelnaudary, France, and the other three to a Poor Clare monastery in northwestern France. Despite this setback, the flame of holy hope was not completely extinguished. The next ten years found the monasteries of our Order praying for a return to its birthplace where Jesus in the Most Blessed Sacrament had been adored night and day without interruption for over 140 years. The more we prayed, the more all our monasteries felt that God wanted us to return to our own "little portion"



Day of Departure from Castelnaudary





Our hearts are filled with thanksgiving to God for all who have helped us by their support and prayers





Home Sweet Home!



A Sister taking a load «off her shoulders» during the big move...



Our «Mother of [illegible]rades»

Finding lots of hidden treasures while cleaning the cabinets, which were preserved with care by our dear Sisters of happy memory.





Our faithful archivist arranging the precious documents of the history of our Order.

«In training» for the next Tour de France, hoping to break Lance Armstrong's record!



and re-establish the Monastery where our beloved Foundress lived and died, and where her remains lie to this day in the cloistered garden. As you know, when God has a mission, He calls whom He chooses to fulfill it. Re-opening our Troyes Monastery was to be one of those times. Some of us, filled with a desire to see our Motherhouse re-opened, proposed going; some were asked by their Abbesses to consider going. And like our Holy Father Francis, the response to Jesus for a mission that He alone could ask was: "This is what I am looking for! This is what I desire to do with all my heart!"

Preparations for re-establishing our Motherhouse began in our monastery of Castelnaudary, France. Mère M. Benigna and Mère Marie du Christ worked untiringly for the re-opening of Troyes. They kept the dream alive over ten years, gathered the input of all the Abbesses, requested the necessary permissions and, at last, welcomed each of the Sisters sent. It was in Castelnaudary that we began to adapt to our new life in a foreign country with all its different customs and to learn the beautiful, but difficult, French language. Thanks to the generosity, prayerful support and continual efforts of our dear Sisters in Castelnaudary, the dream of returning to the Little Portion of our Order was about to become a reality. On August 25th, 2007, Feast of St. Louis, King of France and Patron of the Third Order of Franciscans, Mother M. Emmanuel, Sr. Faustina Marie, and Sr. Margaret Mary left Castelnaudary in an overpacked Ford Fiesta and headed for Troyes to prepare for the other Sisters who would soon follow. With the arrival of Sr. Mary Antoinette, Sr. Mary Rosalia, Sr. Mary Germaine, Sr. Mary Franciscal and Sr. Maria Francesca, we began the as yet unfinished business of settling in. A special debt of gratitude is due to our monasteries in Kollam and Vellore (India), Hanceville and Cleveland (USA) for sending Sisters, and to all who have helped us in so many ways, both materially and spiritually.

Soon after our arrival in Troyes, we set out to accomplish the first task that awaited us— the cleaning and organizing of a large, three-story monastery, not to mention the unpacking of what seemed like mounds of boxes! No time was wasted as we adorned ourselves with work habits and aprons, rolled up our sleeves and gathered our "weapons"— brooms, dustpans, mops and buckets. Each of us took turns braving the heights of ladders, as we cleaned the chapel and other areas of the monastery. Tackling one room at a time, we hope to cover the enitre house and unpack most of the boxes by our first anniversary. We've encountered a few adventures from time to time, such as broken pipes, doing laundry by hand until a washing machine could be installed, along with bearing the cold temperatures before the furnace and individual gas heaters were serviced and could be turned on. All these "surprises" were to be expected, and did not seem to dampen our joyful spirits. Adoration of the Most Blessed Sacrament was also incorporated into our daily schedule, giving us the necessary "spiritual energy" for the other tasks of the

day, with nocturnal adoration every Thursday.

Major repairs are needed everywhere in these old, historical buildings, some of which were constructed in the 1400's. We trust that by saving our pennies from our sewing albs—something we'll begin in January—and with the help of benefactors, we will gradually be able to restore and repair this lovely place. The Chapel, however, is our prioirity since it is the heart of our life. Our day is centered around the sacrifice of the Mass, Eucharistic adoration, and the chanting of the Divine Office, the official prayer of the Church. As Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration, we have the privilege of adoring Christ each day in the Most Blessed Sacrament solemnly exposed in our Chapel . In the name of the whole Church we watch and pray, like sentinels of the dawn, for the light of Christ's coming into the heart of each person, into the darkness of our world, into the joys and sorrows that each one bears, and that Jesus Himself knows all too well. In those hours of silent adoration, we sing Him a song of thanksgiving in our hearts, as our Mother Foundress, Mother Marie de Sainte Claire, told us to do when she gave us, her daughters, the charism of adoration in a spirit of thanksgiving, for that spirit ushers in the life of the Lord. Even in the worst of times, there are blessings all around us, if only we would open our eyes and see. Count your blessings before the Lord, and He will enlighten your heart!

We have been counting our blessings since our arrival; they seem to arrive non-stop! Our beloved Bishop Marc Stenger, priests, religious, and so many others have welcomed us with open arms and hearts. We never anticipated so much. On October 2nd, Feast of the Guardian Angels, our first public Mass was celebrated by our Bishop. He was surrounded by 8 priests and a deacon, while our chapel was overflowing with the faithful of this diocese who came to share their joy and show their prayerful support. Many people come to the monastery, day in and day out, bearing gifts of food and clothing, tokens of their love and thoughtfulness. One gentleman even offered his time and service in tilling our vegetable garden and showing us how and what to plant for each season. The earth has now been turned over and awaits the Spring planting. This is so symbolic, we feel, of our own beginning here at the cradle monastery—the awaiting of new life, new vocations, planted by the Hand of God, to produce a harvest— a hundred-fold, we hope— for the continuation of our Order for many years to come.

Walking in the footsteps of our Holy Father Francis, we take the present moment of each day as God gives it, with all its ups & downs, and ask Him to make of us a community of Adorers for Him and for His Church in the heart of France. May there be many more "new beginnings" for us, and for you, along the way He has prepared for us....



May He bless the work of our hands, which is done for His Honor and Glory!







Community procession to the tomb of our Mother Foundress on the Solemnity of All Saints;



Sowing the first seeds, in hopes of reaping a hundred-fold!

Jesus-
Our heart's delight...
May His Divine blessing be upon you this Christmas and throughout the New Year!



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Merry Christmas

from the Poor Clares in Troyes, France



Thanks to the generosity of the Sisters of Our Lady of the Angels Monastery in Hanceville, Alabama, you can view the progress of the Poor Clares of Troyes--- check out **www,olamshrine.com** under «special features».